PEARL CREDIT UNION BANK



Built for you, Owned by you!

GROUP 5

Guided By: Professor Susan Harmeling

1. ABOUT OUR COMPANY

Pearl Credit Union Bank, or PCUB, is a member-owned bank in Zimbabwe. It takes deposits and operates under the country's banking rules. It is bigger and more regulated than the small savings groups and microfinance places. But it is also nothing like CBZ, Stanbic, Ecobank, CABS, NMB, or FBC. Those banks want collateral. They charge high fees. They mostly serve people with formal jobs. PCUB is built on three main pillars:

- First, no bank fees. Regular banks in Zimbabwe charge somewhere between 2.75 and 6 US dollars a month just to have an account. PCUB does not charge that.
- Second, credit based on behavior, not paperwork. Traditional banks want a title deed or a payslip for very small loans. We look at how money moves. Income coming in. Transactions going out. Savings over time. Whether people pay things back.
- Third, mostly digital. Members use their phones, QR codes, or a kiosk. We do not waste money on big branches.

About 70-80% of Zimbabweans are outside the regular banking system. These are not lazy or poor people. They work. They trade. They save. They take care of families. But banks shut them out because they do not have the right papers. PCUB was built for exactly these people. One thing that makes PCUB different is who owns it. The members do. One member, one vote. If the bank makes a profit, that money goes back into the bank. It strengthens our capital and helps us give members better prices. It does not go to outside shareholders. PCUB is not just about accounts and loans. It helps people build a real financial identity. People who were invisible to banks become visible. Their daily activity becomes their credit record.



2. HOW DOES IT WORK?

Onboarding: You can join through your phone or at a kiosk. We put kiosks in busy places like Mbare Musika, Highfield, Sakubva, and many other high-density areas. Phone sign-up is easy because over 90% of Zimbabweans use WhatsApp, and EcoCash already moves billions through mobile platforms every month. Our KYC checks are automated. We pull from the RBZ credit registry and national ID data. Opening an account takes less than 10 to 15 minutes, with no minimum balance, no need for branch visits, and no verification of formal employment. From the moment they join, members can transact, save, and be part of the ecosystem.

Behavior Capture and Credit Engine: Once you are in, the system starts monitoring. It tracks things like when your salary lands, when you pay bills, when you send money to someone, when you top up EcoCash, when a small business has a good sales day, when you borrow, and whether payments are made on time. All that feeds into what we call the behavior scorecard. This is the part that competitors cannot easily copy.

Old credit systems ask for papers and stop there. We watch what is happening with your money. Is the income steady? How often are you transacting? Are you paying things back? How do you spend? That way, we can give loans to people and businesses who would get rejected at a regular bank, and we keep track of the risk. You do not have to prove you are creditworthy on day one. You build that proof just by using the bank.

Credit Progression: The more consistent you are, the more we trust you. The more we trust you, the more you can borrow.

Stage 1: Small loans from 50 to 500 US dollars to start building a record

Stage 2: Personal loans tied to your salary, and credit cards with on-time repayments

Stage 3: Working capital for small businesses, the more they grow the higher the deposits

Stage 4: Mortgage products starting in Year 3

Approvals are faster and simpler than at the big banks. Our blended rate starts between 10-14% for USD loans. That is much lower than the Zimbabwean sector average 43.5-46.86% for ZiG lending, and USD loan rates of up to 20%-40%.

Payments and the network effect: PCUB offers a money transfer system embedded in the bank's mobile device called Vanish. For all our members, Vanish is for free transfers between members. Our cards work on Visa and Mastercard, and we are working toward Apple Pay and Google Pay once we get the network certification. Finally, small traders can accept payments through POS and QR codes. The more people use it, the better it gets. More users mean more transactions. More transactions mean better data. Better data means we can price credit more accurately

and lower our risk. It is a cycle that feeds itself. It grows because people use it, not because we squeeze them for fees.

3. WHY DOES IT ADD VALUE IN THE MARKETPLACE?

The Gap in the Market: Zimbabwe's banking sector has a structural problem. The RBZ Governor said it in the 2025 Monetary Policy Statement: commercial banks make 22% of their income from fees and only 13.46% from lending. Lending is supposed to be the main thing banks do. Meanwhile, there is a USD 14.2 billion informal economy that cannot get formal credit at all.

The numbers from ZIMSTAT and FinScope states that Zimbabwe's GDP was rebased to USD 52.4 billion for 2025. The informal economy makes up USD 8.6 billion of that. Over 85% of workers are informal, 86% of MSMEs are informal and 94% are unregistered. Only 46% of adults have a bank account and 12% have nothing at all. Right now, nobody in Zimbabwe is running a regulated, zero-fee, behavior-based bank at any real scale. That is the space PCUB is built for.

Three Levels of Value:

For members: A vendor at the market can build a savings record from her daily sales. An informal worker can build credit without a payslip. A small business owner can get working capital based on what the business does, not based on what collateral they can put up. For people who have been locked out their whole lives, this is a real change.

For the market: When members use the platform, their financial lives stop being invisible. Transactions, savings, repayments, all of it starts showing up as data. That helps lenders price risk better. It helps regulators see what is happening. It brings informal activity into the formal system without forcing people to become something they are not. PCUB does not just help the underbanked. It connects them to the rest of the economy.

For the system: Banks in Zimbabwe have been serving the same small slice of people for decades. Every attempt to reach further down has failed because people tried to stretch the old model instead of starting over. PCUB starts with how Zimbabweans handle money. Informally. Socially. On their phones. Then it builds a bank around that. Because members own it, there is no pressure to chase only the safest and richest customers the way commercial banks do.

PCUB is not just a new bank. It is a different way of thinking about who counts as bankable. By pulling together digital access, alternative credit scoring, and a real ecosystem, it goes after the inefficiencies that have held Zimbabwe's financial system back for years. The real innovation is not technology. It is the decision to treat ordinary

financial behavior as something worth measuring. The numbers below sum up the Zimbabwean banking issues and confirm the issues raised above.

Metric	Value	Source
Total Banking Deposits	ZiG 112.8B (~USD 4.2B)	RBZ Mid-Term MPS, June 2025
Total Loans & Advances	ZiG 67.5B (~USD 2.5B)	RBZ Mid-Term MPS, June 2025
Loans-to-Deposits Ratio	56% - 59%	RBZ, June 2025
Non-Performing Loan Ratio	2.9%	RBZ, June 2025
Weighted Avg. Lending Rate (ZiG)	43.5% - 46.86%	RBZ, December 2025
USD Mortgage Rates	14% - 22%	CAHF Housing Finance Yearbook 2024
RBZ Policy Rate	35%	RBZ MPC, December 2025
Bank Income from Fees	22%	RBZ Governor, 2025 MPS
Bank Income from Lending	13.46%	RBZ Governor, 2025 MPS
Monthly Maintenance Fees	USD 2.75 - USD 6	Bank tariff analysis, March 2025
OTC Withdrawal Fees	3% - 3.75%	Bank tariff analysis, March 2025

Exhibit 1: Zimbabwean banking issues

4. WHO IS OUR TARGET MARKET?



Pearl Credit Union Bank (PCUB) is strategically positioned to serve the financially excluded and underserved majority in Zimbabwe, with a primary focus on individuals and small economic actors who are either locked out of or poorly served by the formal banking system. This segment is not marginal, it represents the core of Zimbabwe's economic activity, where approximately 76% of establishments are informal and up to 85% of the workforce operates outside formal structures. Our target market is structured across three distinct but interconnected tiers, each reflecting a different dimension of financial exclusion.

The primary target segment consists of informal sector workers and micro-entrepreneurs, including market traders, street vendors, transport operators, and small-scale service providers. These individuals generate consistent income but lack access to formal financial tools due to absence of collateral, formal documentation, or credit history. As demonstrated through the Christopher Mpofu persona, this group operates in a high-frequency, cash-driven environment where liquidity and speed outweigh formal financial engagement. For this segment, PCUB's behavioral lending model directly addresses the structural mismatch between traditional credit scoring and real economic activity.

The secondary segment includes formally employed but underserved individuals, particularly civil servants such as teachers, nurses, and government workers. While this group has bank accounts and stable income streams, their experience illustrated by the civil servant respondents, reveals a system that provides access without utility. High fees, withdrawal constraints, inflation exposure, and limited credit access reduce banks to transactional intermediaries rather than financial partners. This segment is critical for PCUB not only because of its size but also because it offers predictable cash flows and a foundation for stable deposit mobilization.

The tertiary segment consists of higher-income Zimbabweans and the diaspora, alongside students and young adults entering the financial system. As outlined in the concept paper, the diaspora estimated at around 3 million Zimbabweans remits approximately USD 2 billion annually into the country, representing one of the most stable and significant inflows of capital. This segment, while smaller in volume, offers the highest lifetime value and plays a critical role in enabling more advanced financial products such as savings, credit cards, and mortgages in later stages of PCUB's growth.

Complementing this group are students and young adults, who represent the entry point into the financial ecosystem but are often excluded due to documentation requirements and lack of income. As illustrated through the Nkanyiso persona, this segment is forced to rely on mobile money and informal mechanisms from the outset, limiting their ability to build formal financial histories. By targeting both diaspora-linked inflows and early-stage users, PCUB creates a dual advantage: immediate capital inflows from abroad and long-term customer lifecycle development domestically.

Together, this tier bridges present liquidity and future growth, positioning PCUB not only as a financial service provider, but as a platform that connects Zimbabwe's global financial flows with its next generation of users.

Collectively, these segments reflect a unifying insight, financial exclusion in Zimbabwe is not limited to lack of access, but extends to lack of usability, trust, and relevance across all income levels. PCUB's target market is therefore defined not just by income or employment status, but by systemic misalignment with existing financial infrastructure.

5. EXACTLY WHOM WILL WE MARKET THIS TO AND HOW?



PCUB's go-to-market strategy is built on the principle that distribution and trust not product awareness are the primary barriers to adoption in Zimbabwe's financial landscape. As such, our marketing approach prioritizes physical proximity, behavioral trust-building, and ecosystem integration over traditional advertising. At the execution level, PCUB will prioritize high-density economic zones, specifically informal trading hubs such as Mbare

Musika, Siyaso, Sakubva, and Renkini. These locations concentrate thousands of daily transactions and represent natural aggregation points for our primary market. By deploying a network of low-cost kiosks in these areas, PCUB positions itself directly within the customer's existing economic environment. This is not just a distribution strategy; it is a credibility mechanism. In markets where trust is built through visibility and consistency, physical presence acts as a substitute for brand legacy.

In parallel, PCUB will leverage payroll partnerships to onboard formally employed individuals at scale. Collaborations with institutions such as the Salary Services Bureau enable direct integration into salary flows, significantly reducing customer acquisition costs while ensuring immediate relevance. This channel is particularly effective for civil servants, who already interact with formal systems but lack meaningful financial utility.

Digitally, PCUB adopts a mobile-first engagement model, aligned with Zimbabwe's high mobile penetration and widespread WhatsApp usage. Marketing efforts will focus on low-cost, high-reach platforms such as WhatsApp, Facebook, and SMS-based communication. However, unlike traditional digital campaigns, messaging will be value-led and behavior-focused, emphasizing tangible benefits such as zero fees, instant access to funds, and the ability to build credit without collateral. The objective is not to sell a product, but to reposition banking as a practical, everyday tool.

For younger segments, including students, PCUB will execute on-campus activations across major universities. These activations serve both as onboarding channels and as early trust-building touchpoints. By simplifying account creation and reducing documentation barriers, PCUB captures users at the entry point of their financial journey. Across all channels, word-of-mouth and community validation are central to the marketing strategy. In a low-trust environment, peer endorsement carries more weight than institutional messaging. As such, early adopters, particularly traders and payroll clients that function as organic brand ambassadors, reinforcing credibility through lived experience.

PCUB's marketing approach is not driven by mass media reach, but by embedded presence, strategic partnerships, and trust-based adoption loops. By aligning distribution with how Zimbabweans already live and transact, PCUB positions itself not as a new alternative, but as a natural extension of existing financial behavior.

6. STARTUP COSTS AND BREAKEVEN



If this business is being positioned as a real deposit-taking bank in Zimbabwe, the first big cost is regulation. The Reserve Bank of Zimbabwe's 2025 licensing requirements show that the minimum paid-up capital is the local-currency equivalent of USD 30 million for Tier I banks and USD 20 million for Tier II institutions, and that this

start-up capital cannot be borrowed. The same rules also require ongoing capital adequacy, including a Tier 1 ratio of 8%, capital adequacy ratio of 12%, and leverage ratio of 6%. In simple terms, that means the business needs a very strong capital base before it even starts trading.

That minimum capital is only the beginning. A new digital-first bank would still need money for core banking software, cybersecurity, compliance systems, staffing, liquidity buffers, onboarding channels, and customer support. Zimbabwe's banking sector is not cheap to run. In the first half of 2025, the sector's cost-to-income ratio was 73.01%, which means operating costs were eating up a large share of income. The same RBZ report also shows that banks were earning more from fees and commissions (45.37%) than from interest on loans and advances (31.91%). That matters because a low-fee bank cannot assume the same income structure as traditional banks. It would need more volume, stronger lending, and stricter cost control to survive.

A realistic outside estimate, therefore, is that a serious Zimbabwean digital bank would need more than the legal minimum, not just the minimum itself. A reasonable start-up range would be above USD 20–30 million, and possibly materially higher, if the founders want enough runway for compliance, technology, liquidity, and early losses. Breakeven is also unlikely in Year 1. The safer expectation is that the business would still be loss-making in its first year, then aim for operational breakeven in Year 2 or Year 3, depending on customer growth, loan performance, and funding discipline. That view is also supported by what we see in the wider market: banks face heavy operating costs, and even established institutions still rely strongly on fees to stay profitable



7. HOW MUCH DO WE EXPECT TO SELL IN YEAR 1? YEAR 2?

For a banking business, "sales" should not be thought of like selling bottles or clothes. The real drivers are deposits gathered, loans disbursed, and revenue earned from lending and transactions. A useful place to start is the size of the Zimbabwean market. As of 30 June 2025, the banking sector held ZiG 112.77 billion in deposits, and the sector-wide loans-to-deposits ratio was around 58.6%. That tells us two things. First, the market is large enough to support a new entrant. Second, banks are not lending out every dollar they collect, which leaves room for a stronger credit model if risk is managed well.

Demand also exists outside the traditional banking base. The 2022 FinScope Zimbabwe Consumer Survey found that only about 46% of adults were banked. The 2022 FinScope MSME Survey found that only 40% of business owners were banked, and that only 3% of banked business owners had an account in the name of the business itself. The same MSME survey shows that barriers to banking include bank charges, irregular income, small business size, and lack of registration. This is important because it means a new financial institution does not need to steal customers only from existing banks. It can also grow by serving people and businesses that are still under-served.

Using those outside benchmarks, a conservative Year 1 target would be to capture only a tiny share of the market. For example, if a new entrant captured around 0.25% of sector deposits, that would be roughly ZiG 282 million in deposits. If it then lent in line with the current sector ratio of about 58.6%, the loan book would be around ZiG 165 million. That would be a cautious start, not an aggressive one. A Year 2 target could reasonably be set at 0.5% of sector deposits, or about ZiG 564 million, with a loan book of roughly ZiG 330 million, assuming similar lending discipline. These numbers are much more realistic than trying to scale too fast in a market where trust, compliance, and loan quality matter.

From a revenue point of view, the business should also be careful. Zimbabwean banks often charge visible monthly and transaction fees. For example, Stanbic's SME online banking tariff shows a monthly maintenance fee of USD 3 and USD 5 per RTGS transfer, while AFC's published business conditions show USD business loan pricing in the 13%–18% range for corporate and MSME loans, and National Building Society lists SME loans at 15% per annum and USD mortgage rates at 12% per annum. These benchmarks suggest that a new entrant can compete, but only if it is disciplined about pricing and operating costs. If it chooses a low-fee strategy, then Year 1 and Year 2 revenue will likely be lower per customer than that of incumbents, at least at the start. That means the business must win on volume, trust, and repayment quality, not only on price.

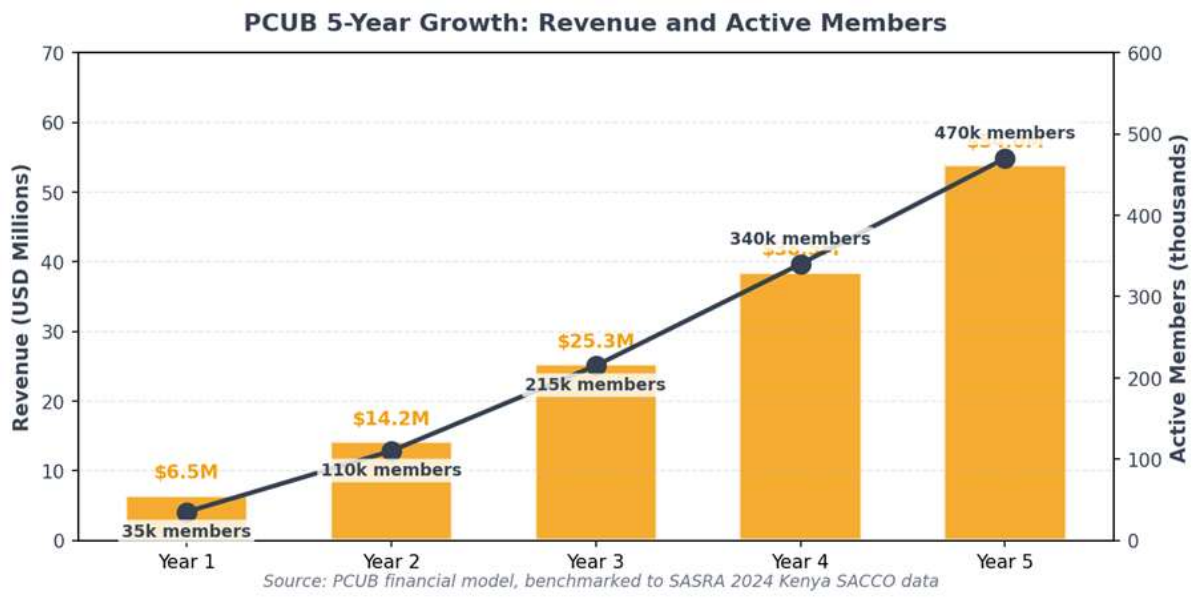


Exhibit 2: PCUB revenue and membership trajectory, Years 1 to 5.

Exhibit 2 shows what the growth looks like. The bars are revenue, climbing from USD 6.5 million in Year 1 to USD 54 million in Year 5. That is roughly an eightfold increase. The line is membership, going from 35,000 to 470,000 over the same period.

The shape of the curves is exactly what you want to see in a credit union model. Steep, but not a hockey stick. The biggest jump is from Year 1 to Year 2, when membership triples and revenue more than doubles. That is when payroll partnerships deepen and kiosks really start pulling their weight. Year 3 is when the model proves itself, with operating profit turning clearly positive. By Year 5, PCUB is mature enough to start thinking about new product lines or regional expansion.

Is a USD 115 million loan book by Year 2 realistic for a new Zimbabwean bank? We think yes. The entire Zimbabwean banking sector loan book was ZiG 67.5 billion in June 2025, or about USD 2.5 billion at the prevailing rate (RBZ, 2025a). USD 115 million is less than 5 percent of that total.

For a wider comparison, the entire Kenyan SACCO sector has 7.39 million members across 355 regulated institutions, and by December 2024, its gross loan book was around USD 6.5 billion. Individual SACCOs like Stima reached USD 515 million in total assets (SASRA, 2025). Against those numbers, PCUB's Year 2 targets are well within what has already been proven in East Africa.

8. WHERE OUR PROJECTIONS CAME FROM?

Every number in this paper comes from a public source. The Zimbabwean sector data comes straight from the Reserve Bank of Zimbabwe. Three documents did most of the heavy lifting: the August 2025 Mid-Term Monetary Policy Review Statement, the February 2025 Monetary Policy Statement (which gave us the full-year 2024 financial soundness indicators, including the Capital Adequacy Ratio of 34.89%), and the Banking Sector Quarterly Industry Report for 31 March 2025.

Market and demand data came from ZIMSTAT's 2023 Economic Census and the 2022 FinScope MSME Survey. The FinScope survey was a joint effort by FinMark Trust, ZIMSTAT, the Reserve Bank, the Ministry of Women Affairs, and the World Bank. ZIMSTAT's 2025 GDP rebasing put the total economy at USD 52.4 billion. We cross-checked that against the IMF's July 2024 Article IV Consultation and the US State Department's 2025 Investment Climate Statement.

Bank pricing benchmarks came from Parliamentary Budget and Finance Committee consultations on the 2025 Monetary Policy Statement.

9. WHAT ARE OUR UNIT COSTS AND UNIT PRICES AND HOW DID WE ARRIVE AT THOSE?

The formula is the standard one: cost of funds, plus operating cost, plus credit risk, plus capital cost, plus margin. The blended lending rate for the first three years lands at about 12% gross. Here is what that looks like by product. Credit-building loans sit at 10-18% APR. That sounds steep on its own, but microfinance institutions in Zimbabwe charge anywhere from 30 to 100%, and informal loan sharks charge 60 to 150%. Payroll-linked personal loans come in at 10 percent APR, while Stanbic and CBZ charge 14 to 22% on USD mortgages. Credit card revolving is at 22%, compared to 25 to 30% in the wider Zimbabwean unsecured market. SME working capital is 14%. Mortgages are 12%, starting in Year 3.

The headline lending rate for the Zimbabwean sector, per RBZ December 2025 data, is somewhere between 43.5-46.86%. That number is misleading on its own, because most of it is ZiG-denominated. USD rates cluster in the 14-22% range. PCUB undercuts commercial banks on USD lending by 2-8 percentage points across most products, and we can still turn a profit because our cost base is lower.

On fees, we go aggressive. The chart below compares what banks charge in Zimbabwe today against what PCUB will charge.

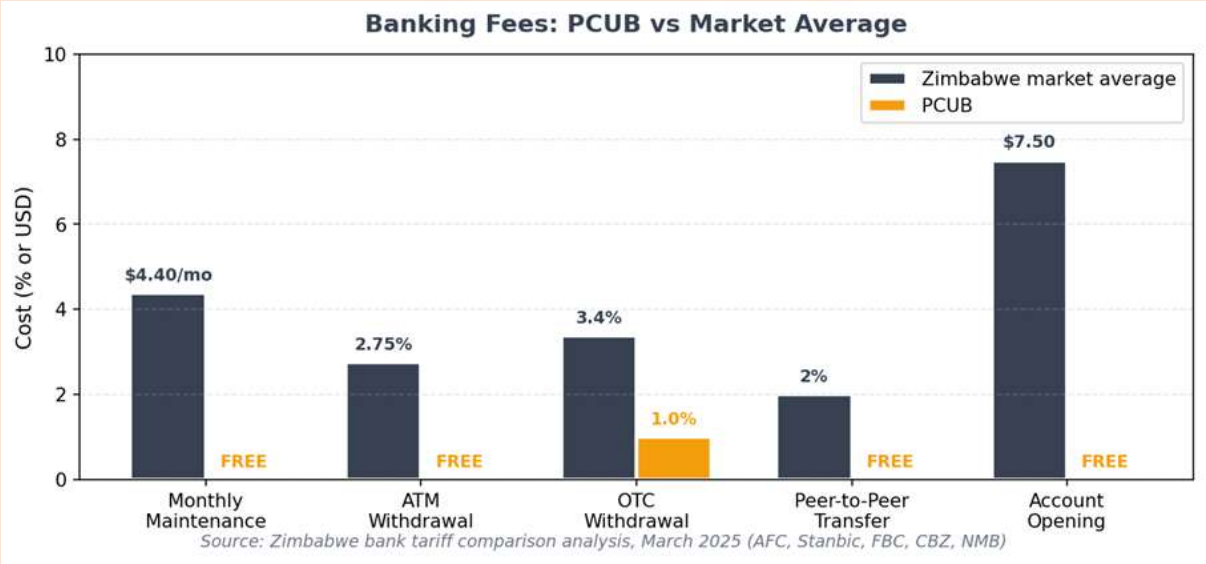


Exhibit 3: Banking Fees Comparison.

Exhibit 3 makes the value proposition visible. The dark bars show what the average Zimbabwean bank customer currently pays across five common services. A monthly

The dark bars show what the average Zimbabwean bank customer pays across five common services today. A USD 4.40 monthly maintenance fee. 2.75% on ATM withdrawals. 3.4% on over-the-counter withdrawals. About 2% on peer-to-peer transfers. USD 7.50 to open an account.

The gold bars show what PCUB charges. For four of those five services, the answer is nothing. The only fee we keep is a 1% over-the-counter withdrawal charge, and that is there only to cover cash handling costs at the kiosk.

How can we afford to do this? Because banks currently pull 22% of their revenue from these fees, and that revenue is not actually cost-based. It is extracted rent. When we hand that rent back to members, we create loyalty that no marketing budget can buy. We earn the money back through lending and through transaction volume. Members who feel they are getting a fair deal do more business with us over time. That is where economics starts to work.

On the cost side, our blended cost of funds in Year 1 is around 5.5%. That comes from mixing Tier 2 debt at 6% with member deposits priced at 2 to 3% on savings and basically zero on current accounts. By Year 5 the blended cost drops to 3.5%, which is below the Kenyan SACCO sector benchmark of roughly 5%. Cost per account falls from USD 82 in Year 1 to USD 41 by Year 5, as digital onboarding gets cheaper and the fixed costs spread across more members. Customer acquisition cost averages USD 12 in Year 1 overall, but it varies a lot by channel. Payroll runs at USD 3 per member because one contract onboards thousands at once. Kiosks run closer to USD 18, because acquiring an informal trader takes more direct work.

Loan loss provisioning starts at a conservative 1.2% of the loan book in Year 1. By Year 5 it drops to 0.75%, as the behavioral data gets sharper at predicting who will repay.



PRE-BMC MODEL

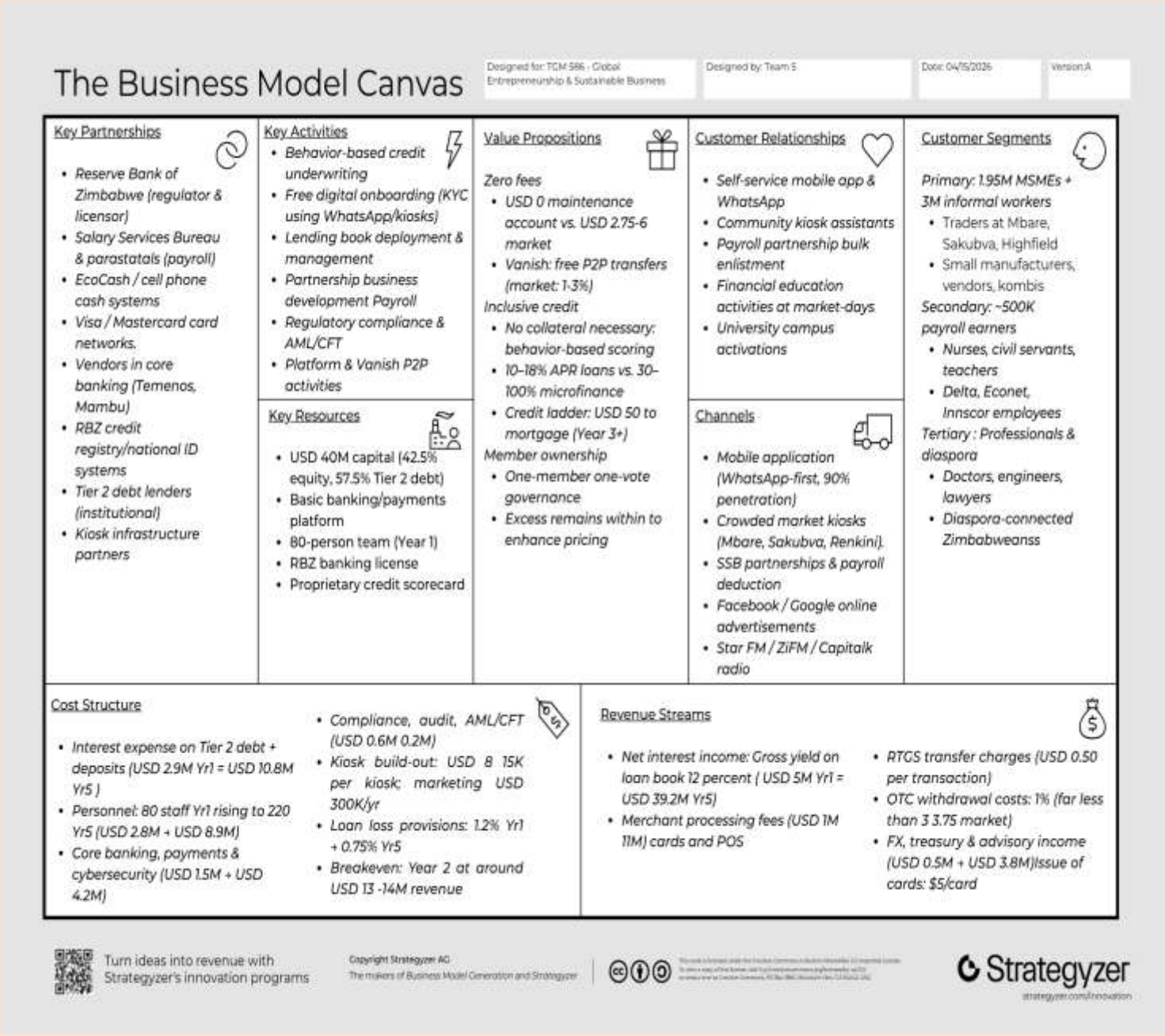


Exhibit 4: PRE-BMC MODEL

CUSTOMER DISCOVERY INTERVIEW SCRIPT (FEEDBACK STAGE)

The interview script was created to test our hypothesis Business Model Canvas of Pearl Credit Union Bank (PCUB). All questions will reveal actual behavioral trends, pain points, and needs gaps in the financial ecosystem in Zimbabwe.

Script Purpose & Methodology: These are face to face or phone interviews with people who have direct lived experience of working within the Zimbabwean formal and informal financial systems. We will emphasize an open discussion rather than direct responses to prevent confirmation bias. PCUB is not introduced by the interviewer at all, or at the very end of the session to avoid leading responses.

Target Interviewee Profile: Our criteria were that (a) they must have lived or worked in Zimbabwe, (b) must have personal experience of using or avoiding the use of formal banking services and (c) must be representative of various economic activities such as salaried workers, self-employed workers and SME owners. Individuals of the diaspora with recent Zimbabwean connections were also included since they were financially connected to their home country.

Interview Questions: The questions are designed to reveal how individuals spend their money, their perceptions of banks, and the largest areas of pain in their daily financial experiences. They jointly assist in testing the hypothesis that fees, trust, access, and loan barriers and service quality are the principal factors that people are avoiding formal banking as well as demonstrate what features would render a new financial service inviting enough to utilize. Prior to customer discovery interviews, our team defined the following hypotheses that were written in our first Business Model Canvas.

Hypothesis	Evidence
Zimbabweans avoid banks primarily due to poor service and high fees	Foundational assumption driving PCUB's zero-fee model
Lack of formal credit access pushes users into informal lending	Basis for our alternative-data credit scoring feature
Mobile money (EcoCash) is the dominant informal payment channel	Informs PCUB's mobile-first infrastructure design
USD cash hoarding is better than bank deposits because of the risk of inflation	Drives our USD-native account offering
Users would switch to new platform if trust and security are established	Tests our member-owned, regulated cooperative model
Digital onboarding would increase access	Hypothesis supporting PCUB's app-based KYC process
SMEs and informal workers are under-served by existing credit scoring	Drives our alternative-data underwriting approach
Community-growth strategy and word-of-mouth are the main drivers of adoption in Zimbabwe	Informs our referral and community-growth strategy

Exhibit 5: Hypothesis for customer interviews.

INTERVIEWS

Interview 1: Josiah Mvindo [Real Estate Specialist | MGM 2027 | +1 (623) 219-5108]

Josiah has been selected due to his being a Zimbabwean professional with a regular salary but cash-based operations. His profile embodies the core target of PCUB, employed people that engage with the banking system at the bare minimum and would like their financial services to be provided in a more mobile-first form. The real estate experience also provides him with an understanding of the property-related financial behaviour and asset-based credit demand.

1. How do you normally spend your money daily?

"I receive my salary through my bank account, but once the money comes in, I usually withdraw a large portion and manage it as cash. For daily transactions, I mostly rely on mobile money like EcoCash or cash because it's faster and more widely accepted. I only use my bank account, when necessary, such as receiving payments or making larger transactions."

2. How have you found the experience with banks or other financial services?

"Banks are helpful for receiving my salary and storing money, but they are not very convenient for everyday use. There are often delays, long lines, and fees that make frequent use costly. Mobile money is more convenient for daily transactions, but it also has transaction fees."

3. Have you ever decided to not use a bank? Why did you decide like that?

"Yes, for daily transactions I often choose not to use my bank account. The main reasons are high transaction fees, limited access, and the time it takes to complete transactions compared to mobile money. Most transactions in Zimbabwe are cash-based."

4. What impact does bank fees/ charges have on your use of financial services?

"Fees make me avoid using my bank account often. I prefer to withdraw cash once and then use other methods to avoid multiple charges. This limits my interaction with the banking system."

5. What do you normally use other than a bank when you need to send money, save, or borrow?

"For sending money, I use EcoCash or give cash directly. For savings, I keep cash in USD at home. For borrowing, I rely on family and friends since formal loan processes are too slow and restrictive."

6. Have you ever required a loan and were unable to secure one? So, what occurred in that case?

"Yes. Even though I receive a salary through the bank, I found it hard to get a loan due to strict requirements and slow processes. I ended up relying on informal borrowing from family and friends."

7. What makes you comfortable with a new financial service?

"Trust takes time. I would only consider a new service after seeing it work consistently over a long time, hearing positive feedback from people I know, and confirming it is supported by a reputable institution or regulated by authorities. Without that, I would be very hesitant."

8. Would you tend to utilize a banking option that is free of charge and not as difficult to access?

"I would be very likely to use it. The key factors would be low or no fees, mobile access, and fast transactions. I would also think about how reliable it is and whether others are already using it."

9. What do you think is the most important thing the perfect banking service to be designed should include?

"It should let me receive my salary, send and receive money easily, and access loans quickly without complicated requirements. Low fees, mobile access, fast transactions, and strong security would be essential."

Key Findings: Even formally employed people with salary accounts draw out at once and go back to cash and EcoCash to use on their daily activities, the bank is a mailbox, not a financial partner. Access to loans is not granted even with formal income, which confirms the credit access gap hypothesis. The high-friction, relationship-based trust in new institutions, regulatory support is as important as the quality of product.

Hypotheses Validated: High transaction fees turn customers away (validated). The de facto payment layer (validated) is mobile money. Working people continue to experience loan rejection because of the strict criteria (validated). There is a high demand for free of charge, mobile-first banking(validated).

Hypotheses Falsified / Complicated: We had first thought that the banks served the salary earners better, yet Josiah demonstrates that this is not the case. The hypothesis that formal employment = credit access is falsified: payslips are not sufficient to open loans in the existing Zimbabwean banking system.

Interview 2: Tadiawanashe Chininga [Accountant | MGM 2026 | +1 (480) 937-7622]

Tadiawanashe was chosen as she is a qualified accountant whose direct work experience is directly related to the banking system in Zimbabwe. Her financial literacy offers a critical perspective on why the even informed users do not trust and do not use formal banking. Her case of blacklisting without prior notice provided a strong real-world experiment of our hypothesis of bank transparency and communication failures to the customer.

1. How do you normally spend your money daily?

"Zimbabwe is mainly a cash country. Because of inflation and currency instability, I avoid keeping money in bank accounts. I convert whatever I receive into US dollars and keep it as cash. Bank usage brings fees, taxes, and transaction charges, so holding cash avoids those unnecessary costs."

2. How have you found the experience with banks or other financial services?

"My experience has mostly been negative. I only used a bank when employed because my employer required salary payments through a bank for tax documentation. As soon as the money arrived, I withdrew it all. Key issues were poor customer service, unreliable systems, and a lack of communication. I was also blacklisted for an overdraft the bank never informed me about, and resolving it took a long time and extra payments, which created lasting distrust."

3. Have you ever decided to not use a bank? Why did you decide that?

"Yes. I often avoid using banks due to lack of reliability and the cash-based economy. Many businesses do not accept cards, so cash is necessary for daily transactions."

4. What impact does bank fees/ charges have on your use of financial services?

"Bank fees are the main reason I avoid banks. Monthly maintenance fees, transaction fees, and taxes mean a large part of my income is lost to charges. It feels like paying the bank just to hold my own money. For sending money, I use World Remit, Western Union, or EcoCash. For borrowing, I rely on microfinance institutions. For saving, I prefer to keep cash outside the bank."

6. Have you ever required a loan and were unable to secure one? So, what occurred in that case?

"Yes. I needed a loan but could not get one because I lacked the required collateral. I ended up depending on support from family and friends, highlighting the limited access to formal credit."

7. What makes you comfortable with a new financial service?

"Low charges, reliable service, and efficient customer support with clear communication would make me willing to try a new service. If those conditions are met, I would give it a chance."

8. Would you tend to utilize a banking option that is free of charge and not as difficult to access?

"I would be moderately likely, around 50% at first. The absence of fees is a major factor, but I would need to build trust gradually before committing fully."

9. What do you dislike or fear about changing to a new banking service?

"I would like to know how long the institution has been operating, whether it is accredited, and whether it is secure against hacking. Concerns about potential bankruptcy and losing my money are significant barriers."

Key Findings: A revelation that is particularly startling: even an accountant with some training was blacklisted without being told in half a year, a structural communication breakdown, not a user error. This confirms the proactive-alert and transparency design by PCUB as being mission-critical. The hoarding of cash is more caused by currency instability than laziness; individuals are rationally saving against inflation. Several layers of fees (VAT +

transaction fee + monthly maintenance) amplify financial pain in a way that cannot be resolved with a single decrease in fees.

Hypotheses Validated: Credit is hampered by collateral requirements even to formally employed earners (validated). Several layers of fees push banking evasions (confirmed). EcoCash bridges the payment gap by banks (validated). Trust should not be achieved due to low fees only(validated).

Hypotheses Falsified / Complicated: We hypothesised that blacklisting was an infrequent edge-case risk. This interview demonstrates that it can happen even to the financially literate people by the systemic bank failures. This amplifies the necessity of real-time alerts and clear overdraft policies as PCUB must-have features.

Interview 3: Lovejoy Moyo [IT Business Solutions Consultant | MGM 2026 | +1 (623) 307-3898]

Lovejoy was selected and interviewed due to her experience in business solutions related to IT that qualifies her as a knowledgeable user of technology and a realistic critic of digital financial products. Being a person who actively handles currency risk, by dividing her income between ZWL and USD, she is the embodiment of the advanced informality of financial strategies that PCUB is trying to formalise and approve. Her view challenges the hypothesis that technologically advanced users can be early adopters of a mobile-first platform.

1. ***How do you normally spend your money daily?***

"I split my salary, using ZWL for daily expenses like groceries and bills while keeping most of my income as USD cash savings due to inflation and currency risk. I avoid holding large balances in ZWL because of the rapid loss of value."

2. ***How have you found the experience with banks or other financial services?***

"My experience has been unstable, marked by policy changes, withdrawal limits, and loss of value during past currency reforms. Trust is low because access to funds is not always guaranteed when you need it most."

3. ***Have you ever decided to not use a bank? Why did you decide that?***

"Yes, I often limit my use of banks due to fear of sudden policy changes and overnight loss of value. Past experiences in Zimbabwe where balances were wiped out strongly influence this decision."

4. ***What impact does bank fees/ charges have on your use of financial services?***

"High bank fees discourage frequent use, especially for small transactions in ZWL. This makes cash and mobile money alternatives much more practical for daily spending."

5. ***What do you normally use other than a bank when you need to send money, save, or borrow?***

“I rely on cash, especially USD, and mobile money platforms for sending and receiving money. Informal savings methods are also common in my circle due to low trust in formal financial systems.”

6. Have you ever required a loan and were unable to secure one? So, what occurred in that case?

“Yes. Accessing loans is tough without collateral or formal documents, even when employed. Many institutions do not consider actual earning capacity, especially for people with mixed incomes.”

7. What makes you comfortable with a new financial service?

“I would need assurance of fund security, easy access to USD savings, and protection against sudden policy changes. Transparency and consistency are critical for me to trust any new platform.”

8. Would you tend to utilize a banking option that is free of charge and not as difficult to access?

“I would likely consider it, especially if it guarantees low fees and protects USD value. Trust, reliability, and flexible withdrawal access would influence my decision the most.”

9. What do you dislike or fear about changing to a new banking service?

“Fear of losing money, hidden fees, and restricted access to USD would make me hesitate. Uncertainty around government or regulatory changes is also a major concern that I cannot overlook.”

10. What do you think is the most important thing the perfect banking service to be designed should include?

“It must protect my money's value, especially in USD, and allow easy, unrestricted access at any time. Stability, low fees, and trustworthiness are the most important features I would want.”

Key Findings: Lovejoy brings up an aspect our initial BMC did not give full importance: currency risk management as a financial behaviour as opposed to a secondary issue. Zimbabweans are conducting advanced hedging choices which cannot be accommodated by formal banks. Another very powerful new question that came up during this interview was: should PCUB not position USD-denominated savings accounts as a core product feature, but as an addition? Historically rooted mistrust caused by currency wipe-outs is also quite deep and indicates that it will take time and an observable track record, rather than a good product design, to build trust.

Hypotheses Validated: Daily transactions are taken over by mobile money (validated). Even currently employed with mixed-currency income people default on formal credit (validated). Accessibility and low switching costs are the major driving factors of switching (validated). One of the biggest and most personal financial anxieties (validated and more acute than originally hypothesised) is policy and regulatory instability.

Hypotheses Falsified / Complicated: We hypothesised that the main aspects of rebuilding trust were lower fees and improved UX. The experience of Lovejoy confirms that regulatory risk anxiety is an independent and more profound

barrier to trust that cannot be overcome only by designing products. PCUB should also seek apparent regulatory clarity, articulate its governance model and USD account protection as a base-not-additional offering.



Interview 4: Kekeli Mensah [Business Analyst | MGM 2027 | +1 (480) 570-8487]

Kekeli was chosen to offer a comparative view of West Africa, Ghana where mobile money infrastructure and digital banking have developed on a separate path as it has in Zimbabwe. He has a structured, evaluative mindset of financial product assessment as a business analyst. His presence assists PCUB in testing the value proposition by seeing if its value proposition is perceived to be relevant in various Sub-Saharan African financial situations and reveals assumptions as to what users believe is baseline versus features truly differentiating.

1. Can you walk me through how you usually manage your money daily?

"I am not a cash user, as a rule. I typically use my bank app, mobile money, or my cards to transfer money. I hardly use cash, occasionally. It has made it convenient as many places take mobile money or e-payments. There have been instances where I did not have cash and someone asked for it that can be inconvenient. But that is how I spend my money most of the time of the day."

2. What has your experience been like using banks or other financial services?

"It has been a bitter experience. It can take up to a day or two to transfer money sometimes as I would prefer it to. There are even hidden charges in some banks, which I despise in my heart and soul. Customer service is also at other times quite poor and difficult to find solutions. In other cases, security has not been ensured as there have been instances where I had unauthorised charges being charged against my account. But overall, it is very accessible and I will accept it."

3. Have you ever chosen not to use a bank? What made you decide that?

"Oh, it is primarily about the secret payments and charges or lack of trust in their security. It may also be a minor thing, such as a dislike of the interface of their bank app. Unless the UI of their bank app is cordial, I would not be

comfortable with it. However, largely it concerns security and ease of opening an account. Some banks demand so much paperwork and I am thinking; I simply want to open an account."

4. How do bank fees or charges affect the way you use financial services?

"Bank charges have an impact on a great deal. I have my money deposited in the bank and you are robbing me of it being in the bank. Considering that there are two banks providing the same services and one is free and the other has a monthly fee, then I will be more persuaded by the free one. I always watch out to that when selecting a financial service."

5. When you need to send money, save, or borrow, what do you usually rely on instead of a bank?

"To be very honest, it is not a culture of borrowing in my place of origin in Ghana. It is as though you have no money, you have no money. Perhaps in the case of a life-or-death scenario, I would count on family. High interest rates form the other reason why I would not always turn to banks as a means of borrowing."

6. Have you ever needed a loan and couldn't get one? What happened in that situation?

"No, I have not required a bank loan which I was unable to get. I do not gravitate towards borrowing and I have not put that aspect of the system to test."

7. What would make you feel comfortable trusting a new financial service?

"Security is the most crucial factor, openness of fees and charges and convenient access such as their application is user-friendly and I do not need to press the secret tabs just to view my balance. Also, a good word of mouth by a person I trust. When it is suggested by one of my acquaintances who I trust, it goes a long way."

8. If there was a banking option with no fees and easier access, how likely would you be to use it? What would influence your decision?

"I would think of it more. I am not, however, on the bandwagon because it is free. It will make me take a more cautious look and think that it may be a trustworthy brand. I am not going to sacrifice on security, though. When your services are free, and the quality is low, free pricing will not make me open an account."

9. What concerns or challenges would make you hesitate to switch to a new banking service?

"Low switching costs when I find what I have in my existing bank is the same in my new bank, why switch? Also, in case the moving over is not smooth and I have to go through a lengthy process, I simply do not have time to do it. The move must be valuable."

10. If you could design the perfect banking service for yourself, what would be the most important thing it must have?

“This is non-negotiable since you are handling the hard-earned money of people and I have had an unauthorized debit. A convenient application interface is also a factor since when something is non-intuitive in its use, that is, when it is clunky and slow, it sends me away. Customer service that can be relied upon to overcome challenges is essential. And one more thing which I believe is frequently neglected: individuals do not have to be tech-savvy or must be always online to avail banking services. It is such accessibility that makes a service inclusive.”

Key Findings: The comparative approach of Kekeli indicates that some pain points such as the presence of hidden charges, ineffective UI, slow transfers, poor customer service are common to all Sub-Saharan African banking users, regardless of their country of origin. An important new insight: The quality of UX and app design is a deal-breaker prior to considering fees to digitally native users. She also emerged the internet connectivity as a physical barrier of inclusion, posing the question of whether PCUB will or will not have a fall-back layer of offline or USSD. Also, her Ghanaian cultural background regarding borrowing proves that not only social attitudes towards debt differ in terms of community, but also that this aspect is also applicable to PCUB designing and marketing its credit products.

Hypotheses Validated: Hidden fees are distrusted everywhere and decisively determine the choice of the platform (confirmed). Onboarding friction and document requirements deter potential users (validated). The mere fact that the price is free does not make it trustworthy, without demonstrating the security and quality (validated). Trust signals that are strong include peer endorsement and word-of-mouth (validated).

Hypotheses Falsified / Complicated: The inclusion problem is automatically addressed with mobile-first digital banking, we hypothesised. This is complicated by Kekeli: digital literacy and internet accessibility is still an actual impediment to the poorer users. Fallback (via USSD or SMS) was not part of our original model, which this interview indicates could be necessary to target the underserved segment PCUB most claims to cater to.

Interview 5: Christopher Mpofu [Informal Trader based in Zimbabwe]

Christopher was chosen because he represents about 60% of the country’s GDP which comes from informal trading. He represents an untapped market and potential for our credit union. His experience in managing a successful small-scale business with the tough financial infrastructure makes him more than relevant in gathering key insights.

1. Can you walk me through how you usually manage your money daily?

“Most of my money I handle day by day. What comes in today is what I use to restock tomorrow. I don’t separate business and personal money; it’s all one pocket. I keep cash on me because it moves faster. Sometimes I use EcoCash when customers don’t have cash, but even that can be a problem because agents don’t always have cash to

give you. So, I try to balance some cash, some mobile money but it's not stable. Planning ahead is difficult because prices change almost every week."

2. What has your experience been like using banks or other financial services?

"To be honest, banks are not very helpful for someone like me. I have an account, but I don't use it much. There are long queues, charges for small transactions, and sometimes you can't even withdraw your own money when you need it. It feels like the system is not built for small traders. Mobile money is better in some ways, but even that has its own challenges with limits and network problems."

3. Have you ever chosen not to use a bank? What made you decide that?

"Yes, most of the time I avoid using the bank. The main reason is access and trust. You can deposit money, but withdrawing it is another story. Also, with inflation, keeping money in the bank feels like you are losing value. It's safer for me to keep stock or cash that I can use immediately."

4. How do bank fees or charges affect the way you use financial services?

"The charges are too much for small amounts. If I deposit or transfer money, I lose part of it to fees. For a small business like mine, that money matters. So I prefer to avoid transactions that will attract charges unless it's necessary. It pushes me to stay informal."

5. When you need to send money, save, or borrow, what do you usually rely on instead of a bank?

"For sending money, I mostly use mobile money or give cash to someone traveling. For saving, I don't really save in the bank. I keep goods or sometimes USD cash if I can get it. Borrowing is usually from friends, family, or other traders. Sometimes suppliers give me goods on credit if they trust me."

6. Have you ever needed a loan and couldn't get one? What happened in that situation?

"Yes, many times. Banks want payslips or collateral, which I don't have. Even microfinance institutions charge very high interest rates. So, when I needed money to expand or restock, I had to rely on informal borrowing. Sometimes that limits how much I can grow because the money is not enough."

7. What would make you feel comfortable trusting a new financial service?

"I would need to see that I can access my money anytime without problems. It must be simple to use, not too many requirements, and no hidden charges. Also, if other traders are using it and it works for them, I can trust it more. Trust comes from experience, not promises."

8. If there was a banking option with no fees and easier access, how likely would you be to use it? What would influence your decision?

"I would try it. But it must be reliable. If I can deposit and withdraw anytime, and the money keeps its value, then it makes sense. Also, if it works well with mobile money or cash, that will help. Convenience is very important for my type of business."

9. What concerns or challenges would make you hesitate to switch to a new banking service?

"My main concern is access to cash. If I can't get my money when I need it, then it's a problem. Also, system failures, network issues, or rules that change, those things suddenly make it risky. I can't afford delays because my business depends on daily turnover."

10. If you could design the perfect banking service for yourself, what would be the most important thing it must have?

"It must be easy to access my money anytime, with no delays. Low or no charges. It should also allow small loans without too many requirements, based on how I run my business. And it must be stable with no sudden changes. For me, the most important thing is reliability. If I can trust it every day, then I can use it."

Key Findings: Christopher operates entirely within a constrained liquidity environment where speed, flexibility, and trust override formality. Banks are largely bypassed due to high fees, limited access to cash, and lack of tailored products for informal traders. His financial behavior is optimized for survival favouring cash, mobile money, and informal credit networks. Inventory effectively becomes his "store of value," reflecting low confidence in formal savings mechanisms.

Hypotheses Validated: High transaction fees discourage bank usage (validated). Informal workers are significantly underserved by formal credit systems (validated). Mobile money dominates as the primary transaction channel (validated). Community-based trust and informal lending structures are critical financial enablers (validated).

Hypotheses Falsified: While digital onboarding could theoretically improve access, Christopher's case shows that usability alone is insufficient liquidity access (cash-in/cash-out reliability) is a more critical constraint. Trust is less about digital convenience and more about consistent, real-world accessibility.

Interview 6: Nkanyiso Ncube [University Student based in Zimbabwe | +263712699600]

Nkanyiso was selected to represent early-stage financial exclusion within the Zimbabwean context, where structural barriers prevent individuals from entering the formal financial system altogether. As a student without sufficient documentation or independent income, she highlights how access challenges begin before cost or product design even become relevant. Her perspective complements the other personas by illustrating that financial exclusion is not only experienced by informal traders or underserved workers, but also by young, educated individuals at the point

of entry into the economy. This makes her a critical lens for understanding how gaps in onboarding, identity verification, and trust formation limit long-term financial inclusion.

1. Can you walk me through how you usually manage your money daily?

"My money mostly comes from home, so I must stretch it as much as possible. I try to budget, but it's difficult because prices keep changing. Some days I rely on cash, other times mobile money, depending on what is available. I don't really plan long-term it's more about making sure I have enough for food, transport, and maybe data bundles."

2. What has your experience been like using banks or other financial services?

"I have a bank account, but I don't use it often. It's mostly for receiving money from my parents. The problem is accessing the money sometimes there are long queues or withdrawal limits. Mobile money is more convenient, but it's not always reliable either. So, I just use whatever works at that moment."

3. Have you ever chosen not to use a bank? What made you decide that?

"Yes, I prefer not to keep money in the bank unless I must. The charges are high, and sometimes you can't withdraw when you need to. Also, with inflation, money loses value quickly, so it feels better to use it immediately rather than store it in the bank."

4. How do bank fees or charges affect the way you use financial services?

"They make a big difference. As a student, even small charges add up. If I receive money and then lose part of it to fees, it affects my budget. So, I try to minimize transactions that involve bank charges and rather use cash or mobile money where possible."

5. When you need to send money, save, or borrow, what do you usually rely on instead of a bank?

"For sending money, I mostly use mobile money. For saving, I don't really use formal systems I just keep cash or sometimes ask someone I trust to hold money for me. Borrowing is usually from friends or classmates, especially towards the end of the month."

6. Have you ever needed a loan and couldn't get one? What happened in that situation?

"Yes, but as a student, it's almost impossible to get a loan from a bank. They require income or collateral. So, when I needed money, I had to rely on friends or family. Sometimes that means going without certain things if no one can help."

7. What would make you feel comfortable trusting a new financial service?

"It should be easy to use and not require too many documents. I would also need to know that I can access my money anytime. If other students are using it and it works well, that would also build trust."

8. If there was a banking option with no fees and easier access, how likely would you be to use it? What would influence your decision?

"I would use it. As a student, avoiding fees would really help. But it must be reliable and easy to access, especially through my phone. If I can receive, send, and withdraw money without problems, then it would be very useful."

9. What concerns or challenges would make you hesitate to switch to a new banking service?

"I would worry about whether I can access my money when I need it. Also, network issues or system failures are a big concern. If the service is not widely accepted, it becomes difficult to use in everyday situations."

10. If you could design the perfect banking service for yourself, what would be the most important thing it must have?

"It should have no or very low charges, and it must be easy to access anytime. It should also work well with mobile money and allow small amounts to be managed easily. For me, the most important thing is convenience and reliability."

Key Findings: Nkanyiso represents early-stage financial exclusion driven by structural barriers, particularly documentation requirements. Without access to formal banking, she defaults to mobile money and informal coping mechanisms. Her financial behavior is reactive and consumption-focused, with limited capacity to save or plan. The system effectively excludes her before she can even participate, reinforcing dependency on informal channels.

Hypotheses Validated: Digital onboarding has the potential to increase access (validated), particularly where traditional KYC requirements are restrictive. Mobile money is the default financial layer for underserved populations (validated). There is strong demand for low-cost, accessible financial services (validated).

Hypotheses Falsified: The assumption that access barriers are primarily cost-driven is incomplete—documentation and onboarding requirements are equally, if not more, restrictive. Additionally, trust in financial services is not just about affordability but about peer validation and ease of entry.

Interview 7: Aleck Phiri [Teacher based in Zimbabwe | +263776015059]

Aleck was selected to represent the formally employed segment, particularly civil servants who make up a significant share of Zimbabwe's workforce. Despite having stable income and bank access, his experience highlights a critical disconnect and formal inclusion does not translate into meaningful financial empowerment. His perspective demonstrates how systemic issues such as inflation, high fees, limited cash access, and restrictive lending criteria undermine the value of being banked. This makes him essential in illustrating that the challenge is not just access, but the overall effectiveness and reliability of financial services within the formal system

1. Can you walk me through how you usually manage your money daily?

"As a teacher, my salary comes once a month, so I try to budget carefully. But it's difficult because by the time I receive it, prices have already gone up. I usually withdraw a portion in cash immediately and use mobile money for the rest. Most of the money goes to essentials, food, transport, and my children's school fees. There's very little left to save."

2. What has your experience been like using banks or other financial services?

"I have a bank account because that's where my salary is paid. But the experience is not always smooth. There are withdrawal limits, long queues, and sometimes system issues. Even though I am formally employed, I still struggle to access my money when I need it. It can be frustrating."

3. Have you ever chosen not to use a bank? What made you decide that?

"Yes, after withdrawing my salary, I try not to keep money in the bank for long. The value can change quickly because of inflation, and access is not always guaranteed. So, I prefer to hold cash or convert some of it into goods or USD if possible."

4. How do bank fees or charges affect the way you use financial services?

"The fees reduce the already small salary we receive. Every transaction like withdrawals, transfers come with a cost. Over time, it adds up. It forces me to minimize how often I use the bank, even though my salary comes through it."

5. When you need to send money, save, or borrow, what do you usually rely on instead of a bank?

"For sending money, I often use mobile money because it's quicker. Saving is difficult, I try to keep some money in USD or invest in household goods. For borrowing, I rely on savings clubs or colleagues. We support each other because formal systems are not always accessible or affordable."

6. Have you ever needed a loan and couldn't get one? What happened in that situation?

"Yes, even as a civil servant, getting a loan is not easy. The interest rates are very high, and repayment terms are strict. Sometimes the loans are not enough to meet real needs. In those situations, I rely on borrowing from colleagues or cutting back on expenses."

7. What would make you feel comfortable trusting a new financial service?

"It must be reliable and consistent. I need to know that my money is safe and accessible at any time. Transparency is also important, no hidden charges. If it can also protect the value of my money, that would build trust."

8. If there was a banking option with no fees and easier access, how likely would you be to use it? What would influence your decision?

"I would consider it. But reliability is key. If I can access my salary without delays, withdraw when needed, and avoid unnecessary charges, it would make a big difference. Stability would influence my decision the most."

9. What concerns or challenges would make you hesitate to switch to a new banking service?

"My concern would be whether the system is stable and widely accepted. If it fails or is not recognized in many places, it becomes difficult to rely on it. I also worry about sudden policy changes, which we have seen before."

10. If you could design the perfect banking service for yourself, what would be the most important thing it must have?

"It must guarantee access to my money at any time. Low or no charges, and the ability to maintain value despite inflation. It should also offer fair loan options for people like us. For me, the most important thing is stability and trust."

Key Findings: Although formally employed, Aleck's experience highlights systemic inefficiencies within the banking sector. His bank account functions primarily as a salary collection point rather than a financial management tool. Inflation, withdrawal constraints, and high fees drive him toward immediate cash withdrawal and alternative value storage strategies. Even with stable income, access to affordable credit remains limited, reinforcing a disconnect between formal employment and financial inclusion.

Hypotheses Validated: Formal sector employees still face significant barriers to accessing credit (validated). High transaction fees reduce engagement with banking services (validated). There is strong demand for stable, low-cost, and reliable financial solutions (validated).

Hypotheses Falsified: The assumption that formal employment ensures better access to financial services is disproven. Additionally, while trust and security are important, Aleck's behavior shows that value preservation (inflation protection) is equally critical in driving financial decision-making suggesting that stability of funds is as important as accessibility.

Interview 8: Tarisayi Gutsa [Food Manufacturing Industry | +263714718008]

This entrepreneur was chosen because he operates in the manufacturing sector, which requires regular handling of money, suppliers, and production costs. His business is also formalized, which makes him a good example of someone who interacts with both formal and informal financial systems. He was also selected because he has experience dealing with banks, loans, and reinvestment decisions. This makes his insights valuable in understanding how small manufacturing businesses manage money in Zimbabwe.

1. Can you walk me through how you usually manage your money daily?

“I manage my money very carefully because the business environment in Zimbabwe is not stable. Most of my money is kept in USD cash because it holds value better. I do not trust keeping large amounts in the bank. For daily transactions, I use EcoCash. It is fast and easy for paying workers or buying small supplies. When I make sales, I do not keep the money for long. I quickly reinvest it into the business. I buy raw materials or fix equipment. I also keep records in a notebook. It is simple, but it helps me track my income and expenses. I make sure I always know how much money I have.”

2. What has your experience been like using banks or other financial services?

“My experience with banks has not been very good. Banks are useful for some things like receiving large payments. But for daily use, they are not reliable. There are delays sometimes. Systems go down. Also, in the past, people in Zimbabwe lost money or could not access it. That history still affects how we think. I prefer mobile money because it is faster and more convenient.”

3. Have you ever chosen not to use a bank? What made you decide that?

“Yes, I have chosen not to use banks for daily operations. I prefer to have full control over my money. With banks, there are restrictions. Sometimes you cannot withdraw your money easily. That is a big problem for a business. So, I keep most of my money outside the bank.”

4. How do bank fees or charges affect the way you use financial services?

“Bank fees are too high. Every transaction cost money. Deposits, withdrawals, transfers everything has a charge. For a small business, this reduces profits. So, I try to limit how often I use the bank. I only use it when it is necessary.”

5. When you need to send money, save, or borrow, what do you usually rely on instead of a bank?

“I use EcoCash for sending money. It is fast and accepted almost everywhere. For saving, I keep USD cash. Sometimes I also invest in stock for the business. That way, my money is not just sitting. For borrowing, I rely on family or business partners. It is easier and faster than banks.”

6. Have you ever needed a loan and couldn’t get one? What happened in that situation?

“Yes, I applied for a loan before and I was rejected. The bank wanted collateral and formal records. I did not have those at the time. It was frustrating because I needed the money to expand. Instead, I had to grow slowly using my own profits. It delayed my business, but I had no other option.”

7. What would make you feel comfortable trusting a new financial service?

“I need reliability. I want to know that I can access my money anytime. The system must be clear. No hidden charges. Everything must be transparent. Also, good customer support is important. If there is a problem, it must be solved quickly.”

8. If there was a banking option with no fees and easier access, how likely would you be to use it? What would influence your decision?

“I would be interested, but I would not rush into it. I would first observe how it works. In Zimbabwe, trust is built slowly. I would need to see other people using it successfully. If it proves reliable, then I would start using it more.

9. What concerns or challenges would make you hesitate to switch to a new banking service?

“My biggest concern is losing money. I also worry about system failures. If the system is not stable, I will not use it. Security is also important. There are many scams, so I need to feel safe.”

10. If you could design the perfect banking service for yourself, what would be the most important thing it must have?

“The most important thing is easy access to money. I should be able to withdraw anytime. It should have low or no fees. It should also support small businesses with simple loans and easy systems.”

Key Findings: This interview shows that trust is a big problem when it comes to banks in Zimbabwe. The entrepreneur does not fully trust banks. He prefers to keep money in USD cash or use mobile money. These options give him quick access and more control. He only uses banks when it is necessary. Daily business is done outside the banking system. This shows that banks are not the main tool for managing money. Another important point is that he relies on informal systems. He reinvests profits and borrows from people he knows. Getting a loan from a bank is difficult because of strict requirements. He is open to new financial services. But he will not rush. He wants to see proof that the system works. Trust takes time.

Hypotheses Validated: The interview confirms that many entrepreneurs do not fully trust banks. It also shows that mobile money and cash are preferred for daily use. High bank fees are a problem and reduce usage. It also confirms that access to loans is difficult for small businesses. The use of informal networks like family and partners is also very common.

Hypotheses Falsified: The idea that entrepreneurs quickly adopt new financial services is not true. This entrepreneur is very cautious. He wants to observe first. The idea that banks are the main financial tool for small businesses is also not correct. They are only used when necessary.

Interview 9: Mary Mugabe [Retail Shop | +263781477218]

This entrepreneur was chosen because she runs a small retail business that deals with customers daily. Retail businesses handle frequent transactions, which makes them a good example for understanding how people manage money in real time. She was also selected because she represents many small shop owners in Zimbabwe who rely heavily on cash and mobile money. Her experience helps show how financial services are used at a daily operational level.

1. Can you walk me through how you usually manage your money daily?

"I handle money every day because I run a shop. Most customers pay in cash or EcoCash. I separate my business money from personal money. This helps me know if I am making a profit. I restock often because prices change quickly in Zimbabwe. If I delay, I lose money. So, I manage my cash carefully."

2. What has your experience been like using banks or other financial services?

"Banks are slow and not convenient. There are long queues. Sometimes systems are down. I only use banks for large transactions. For daily business, I prefer mobile money because it is faster."

3. Have you ever chosen not to use a bank? What made you decide that?

"Yes, I stopped using banks for daily work. It takes too much time. Mobile money is faster and easier. Customers also prefer it."

4. How do bank fees or charges affect the way you use financial services?

"Fees are too high. Every transaction reduces my profit. So, I avoid unnecessary bank transactions."

5. When you need to send money, save, or borrow, what do you usually rely on instead of a bank?

"I use EcoCash and cash. I also join savings groups. These groups help me save money and access funds when needed."

6. Have you ever needed a loan and couldn't get one? What happened in that situation?

"Yes, I was rejected by a bank because I did not have formal records. I borrowed from a friend instead. It was faster and easier."

7. What would make you feel comfortable trusting a new financial service?

"For me to trust a new financial service, it must be simple and reliable. I run a shop, so I do not have time to deal with complicated systems. It must work every time without delays. I also want clear information. The charges must be explained properly. There should be no hidden costs. Customer support is very important. If something goes wrong, I need quick help. I also trust services that other people are already using. In Zimbabwe, word of mouth is very important."

8. If there was a banking option with no fees and easier access, how likely would you be to use it? What would influence your decision?

"I would be very interested in using it. Low or no fees would help my business a lot. It would reduce my costs and increase my profits. However, I would not switch immediately. I would first try it with small amounts. I would also ask other business owners about their experience. If the service is easy to use and works well on my phone, then I would fully adopt it."

9. What concerns or challenges would make you hesitate to switch to a new banking service?

"My biggest concern is trust. If I feel the service is not secure or has hidden charges, I will not use it. If the system is slow, it will affect my business. Customers expect fast service. I also worry about system failures. If payments do not go through, I lose sales. That is a big problem."

10. If you could design the perfect banking service for yourself, what would be the most important thing it must have?

"The most important thing is speed. Transactions must be fast. There should be no delays. It should also have low charges. Small businesses cannot afford high fees. The service must be easy to use on a phone. Most of my work is done through mobile. It should also allow easy saving and access to small loans. This would help me grow my business."

Key Findings: This interview shows that speed and convenience are very important in retail. The entrepreneur needs fast transactions to serve customers. Banks are too slow for daily use. That is why she prefers mobile money. Cost is also very important. Bank fees reduce profits. This makes her avoid using banks unless it is necessary. Another key point is trust. She trusts services that other people are already using. Word of mouth is very important. If others recommend it, she is more likely to try it. She is interested in better financial services. But they must be simple, fast, and reliable.

Hypotheses Validated: This interview confirms that small business owners prefer speed and convenience over formal banking. It also shows that bank fees are a major issue. Mobile money is widely used for daily transactions. Informal savings systems are also important. Trust is influenced by what other people say and use.

Hypotheses Falsified: The idea that entrepreneurs prefer banks for daily business is not true. Banks are seen as slow and inconvenient. The idea that cost is not important is also wrong. Cost is one of the biggest concerns for this entrepreneur.

Interview 10: Nyasha Murigi [Transport Operator | +263718562701]

This entrepreneur was chosen because he operates in the service industry, where income is not always stable. His business depends on daily earnings, which makes financial flexibility very important. He was also selected because he deals with different types of payments and clients, giving a broader view of how money flows in the service sector. His experience helps show how entrepreneurs manage financial uncertainty in Zimbabwe.

1. Can you walk me through how you usually manage your money daily?

"I receive payments in different forms. Some clients pay in USD. Others use mobile money. I try to convert money quickly because of inflation. I do not want to lose value. I also track my income using simple methods like a notebook."

2. What has your experience been like using banks or other financial services?

"Banks are okay for receiving money. But they are not flexible. Sometimes there are withdrawal limits. This makes it hard to run a business."

3. Have you ever chosen not to use a bank? What made you decide that?

"Yes, I reduced using banks. I prefer having direct access to my money. Restrictions make it difficult to operate freely."

4. How do bank fees or charges affect the way you use financial services?

"Bank fees affect me a lot. Even small charges can become a big problem over time. When I receive payments or transfer money, there is always a deduction. For a service-based business, income is not always consistent. So, these charges reduce what I take home. Because of this, I try to avoid using the bank unless it is necessary. Instead, I use options that have lower or more predictable costs. I always think about how to protect my income."

5. When you need to send money, save, or borrow, what do you usually rely on instead of a bank?

"I mainly use mobile money to send and receive payments. It is fast and works well for most of my clients. For saving, I do not rely on the bank. I prefer keeping USD cash or investing in things like fuel or spare parts. These are things I will use later in the business. When I need money, I usually turn to friends, family, or other people. It is easier and faster than going through a bank process."

6. Have you ever needed a loan and couldn't get one? What happened in that situation?

"Yes, I have experienced that. I once needed a loan to expand my business. I wanted to improve my operations and increase income. I went to the bank, but they refused my application. They said I did not have proper financial records and stable income proof. It was frustrating because I knew my business was working. I just did not have formal documentation. In the end, I had to delay my plans and continue growing slowly using my own money."

7. What would make you feel comfortable trusting a new financial service?

"For me to trust a new financial service, it must be very reliable. I need to know that it will work every time I use it. Security is also very important. I want to feel that my money is safe. The service must also be simple to use. If it is too complicated, I will not use it. Clear communication and good customer support would also help build trust."

8. If there were a banking option with no fees and easier access, how likely would you be to use it? What would influence your decision?

"I would be interested in such a service. No fees and easy access are very attractive. However, I would not start using it immediately. I would first test it with small amounts. I would also observe how other people are using it. If it proves to be reliable over time, then I would fully adopt it."

9. What concerns or challenges would make you hesitate to switch to a new banking service?

"My biggest concern is reliability. If the system fails often, I will not use it. My business depends on quick access to money. I also worry about scams and fraud. There are many cases where people lose money through fake systems. Another concern is hidden charges. If the service is not transparent, I will not trust it."

10. If you could design the perfect banking service for yourself, what would be the most important thing it must have?

"The most important thing would be flexibility. I want a service that understands how small businesses operate. It should allow easy access to money at any time. It should also have low or no fees. I would also want access to small loans without strict requirements. The system should be simple, fast, and reliable. Most importantly, it should make business easier, not harder."

Key Findings: This interview shows how economic conditions affect financial decisions. The entrepreneur tries to protect his money from losing value. He converts money quickly and invests in useful assets. He also needs flexibility. His income is not always stable. Banks are too rigid for his situation. Withdrawal limits and rules make it hard to operate. He values security and reliability. He uses informal methods and reinvests his own money.

Hypotheses Validated: This interview confirms that economic instability affects how people manage money. It also shows that entrepreneurs prefer flexible systems. Banks are seen as restrictive. Access to loans is difficult. Informal systems are widely used.

Hypotheses Falsified: The idea that entrepreneurs depend on banks to grow their businesses is not correct. This entrepreneur mostly relies on himself and informal networks. The idea that complex systems are better is also false. He prefers simple and easy solutions.

POST-BMC MODEL

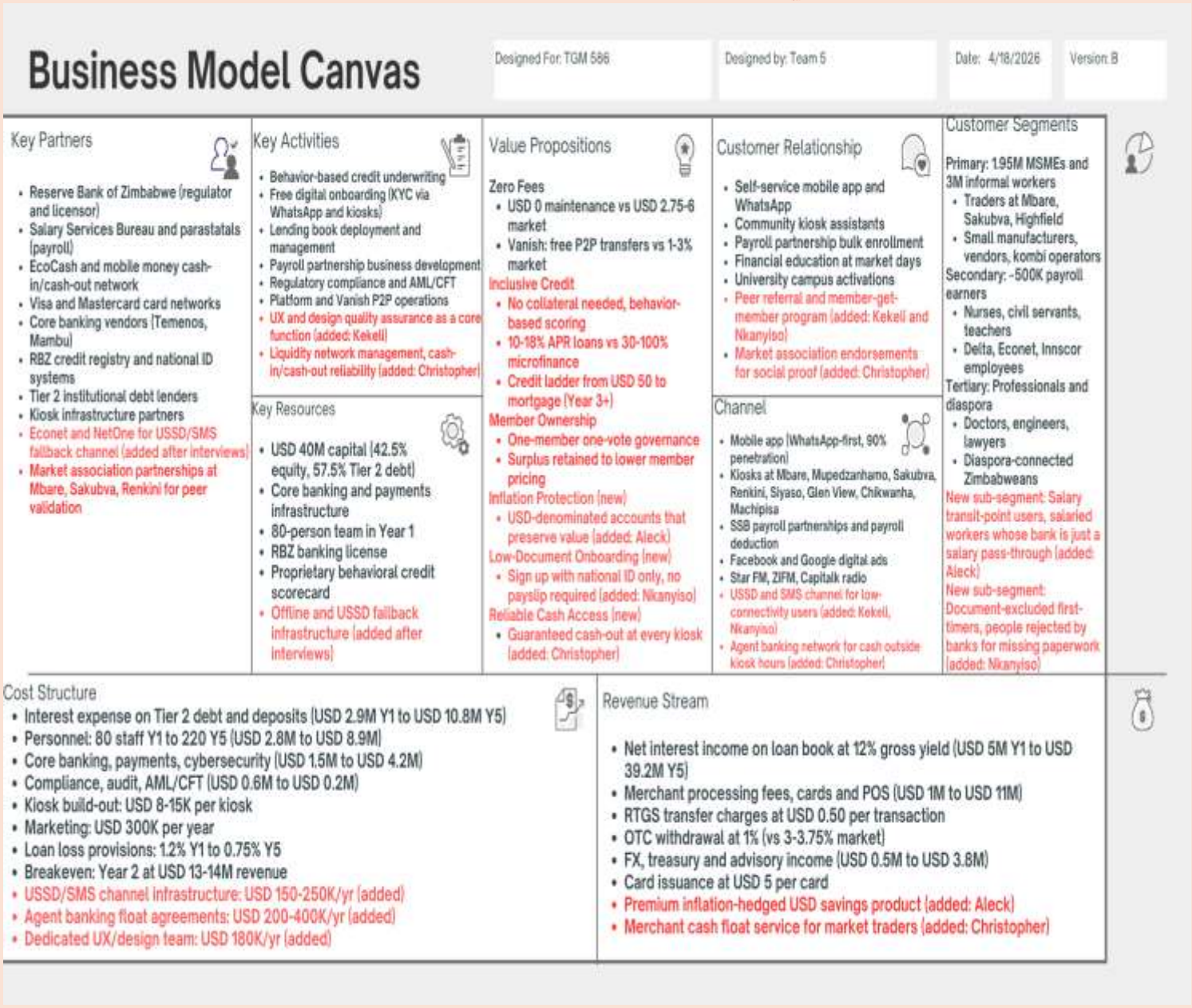


Exhibit 6: Post-BMC model.